

THE RISE OF RADICAL HINDUTVA HELPED THE PFI AS IT PLAYED ON THE FEARS OF MUSLIMS THAT THEIR EXISTING LEADERSHIP WOULD BE INEFFECTUAL IN A CRISIS

diverted, could be a big concern for the authorities.

PFI's fund-raising came under the ED scanner again in 2020 when the UP police arrested some alleged members in Mathura while on their way to Hathras in the aftermath of the gangrape and death of a 19-year-old Dalit girl. The UP police charged them with attempts "to disturb communal harmony" and, based on the case, the ED launched another money-laundering probe, filing a chargesheet in February 2021 against five members of the PFI and the Campus Front of India (CFI). The agency claims that Rs 1.36 crore was collected to fund the anti-CAA protests, Delhi riots and Hathras protests.

The ED also alleges that more than Rs 100 crore has been deposited in PFI accounts over the years. In December last year, the agency cited documents to indicate the money-laundering activities of PFI through various projects in Kerala, including through realty firm Munnar Villa Vista Pvt Ltd. "Acquisition of foreign properties by PFI leaders, including a bar and restaurant in Abu Dhabi, is also under investigation," the agency alleged.

PFI general secretary Anis Ahmed has rubbished the claims. "First, it claimed we have Rs 200 crore in our accounts. Then it came down to Rs 120 crore...now they have found only Rs 60 crore collected over 12 years," he said in an interview.

Political observers say PFI represented a new brand of Muslim politics in India, based more on empowerment and addressing the socioeconomic grievances of the community. With the rise of radical Hinduism, the Muslims felt socially and politically marginalised with a realisation that their existing leadership had failed to offer them a sense of security. The PFI deftly played on these fears and presented itself as a protector of the community. In fact, the government's regular flagging of the outfit as a threat worked to the PFI's advantage, giving it more publicity and acceptance, particularly among the marginalised.

Indeed, the PFI playbook borrowed much from right-wing Hindutva outfits such as the RSS and VHP. "It belonged among the new model of radical pressure groups such as the VHP and Bajrang Dal that have emerged in the past 30-40 years. These groups seek to evoke emotions and create legitimacy for themselves. They represent themselves as stakeholders who are fighting back for the community," says Ahmed. Confronted with the allegations of arms training, PFI leaders often point out how such accusation have also come up against Hindu right-wing organisations such as the RSS and Bajrang Dal, yet these outfits face no punitive action.

FUNDAMENTAL SHIFT IN MUSLIM POLITICS

According to German scholar Arndt Emmerich, the emergence of the PFI signalled 'a fundamental shift' in Muslim politics in India, from one that is identity-based and inward-looking to an inclusive and confident debate centred on minority empowerment through political education and legal activism. His research paper, 'Political education and legal pragmatism of Muslim organizations in India: A study of the changing nature of Muslim minority politics', points out that the biggest reason behind PFI's popularity was its agenda of empowering Muslims through legal education and by making them aware of their constitutional rights.

This focus on legal empowerment reduced the insecurity among Muslims and 'raised their confidence in the context of regular intimidation by Hindu nationalist groups, police harassment and racial profiling of the Muslim community'. According to the Prison Statistics of India, over 30 per cent of all detainees in Indian prisons in 2021 were Muslims, a disproportionately high share given that they constitute just 14.2 per cent of the population. Legal aid was such an important element of the group's strategy that it helped prospective law students get international scholarships on the condition that they join the PFI upon returning to India.

The outfit, though disbanded, may still opt for a legal battle by contesting the ban in courts, an intent that its student wing, the CFI, has expressed. In public perception, however, the organisation is on the backfoot even among the Muslims whom they seek to represent. Already facing flak over its regressive stand on issues such as pre-marital relationships, the comprehensive ban that includes all its fronts will cripple the entity. Leaders of several Muslim organisations such as the All India Muslim Jamaat, Muslim Student Organisation of India, All India Tanzeem Ulama-e-Islam, Kul Hind Markazi Imam Council, All India Pasmanda Muslim Mahaz have said that PFI activities are not in their interest and welcomed the ban. The outfit's focus will be to get their leaders out on bail. It will be an uphill task moving forward, even in a new avatar. ■

–with Jeemon Jacob, Prashant Srivastava, Romita Datta, Rahul Noronha and Amarnath K. Menon